

Silent Storyteller

A Kolkata teacher uses the traditional art of mime to reach out to impaired children from city slums and introduces both skill and dignity to their lives



SUVASHIS MULLICK

GOSWAMI AT A SESSION WITH HIS STUDENTS

By Sarbani Sen

Ashis Hazra (11) lifts his arms and the kite soars in the sky. Though he cannot speak, his actions are clear and confident. The man behind Hazra's lithe body language is Niranjan Goswami (60)—this year's Padma Shri awardee and an expert in *mukabhinaya* or mime—who has been teaching the art to differently-abled children from slums for the past 20 years. Goswami, who founded the Indian Mime Theatre (IMT) in 1976 to revive the traditional art, takes pride in teaching special children. He would bring them home and teach them the art of acting when he used to find them loitering around his neighbourhood. Hazra's talent fetched him recognition by the Union Ministry of Culture in the form of a stipend of Rs 600 per month.

The veteran artiste uses his facial expressions as tools, and the movement of his hands and legs is his language. "I try to avoid the sign language as lip-reading helps them understand and express themselves better. A mime artiste needs to calculate his movements as there is a timely variation in a story," says Goswami. He even

organises cultural activities where normal and differently-abled students can perform together.

Goswami learnt sign language from his student Sanjit Kumar Das who had a hearing impairment. "Das taught me to interact in sign language and I taught him to perform the art through silence," he says. Now, Das runs the Central Calcutta Mime Theatre. Another special student, Kalpataru Guha, who is self-employed, was honoured by the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment. Guha, who stays in Asansol, heads the Amiya Memorial Creative Arts, and teaches mime art.

Has he ever lost his patience dealing with his students? "Patience has only helped make our bonds stronger. My special students are fast learners compared to the others and are sincere in their work," says Goswami. The artiste has been travelling all over India conducting mime workshops at special schools. "Not all school authorities are keen to hold such activities. But the cheerful faces of these children say a hundred words after the activities are over," smiles Goswami. ■